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DAVID SHAW
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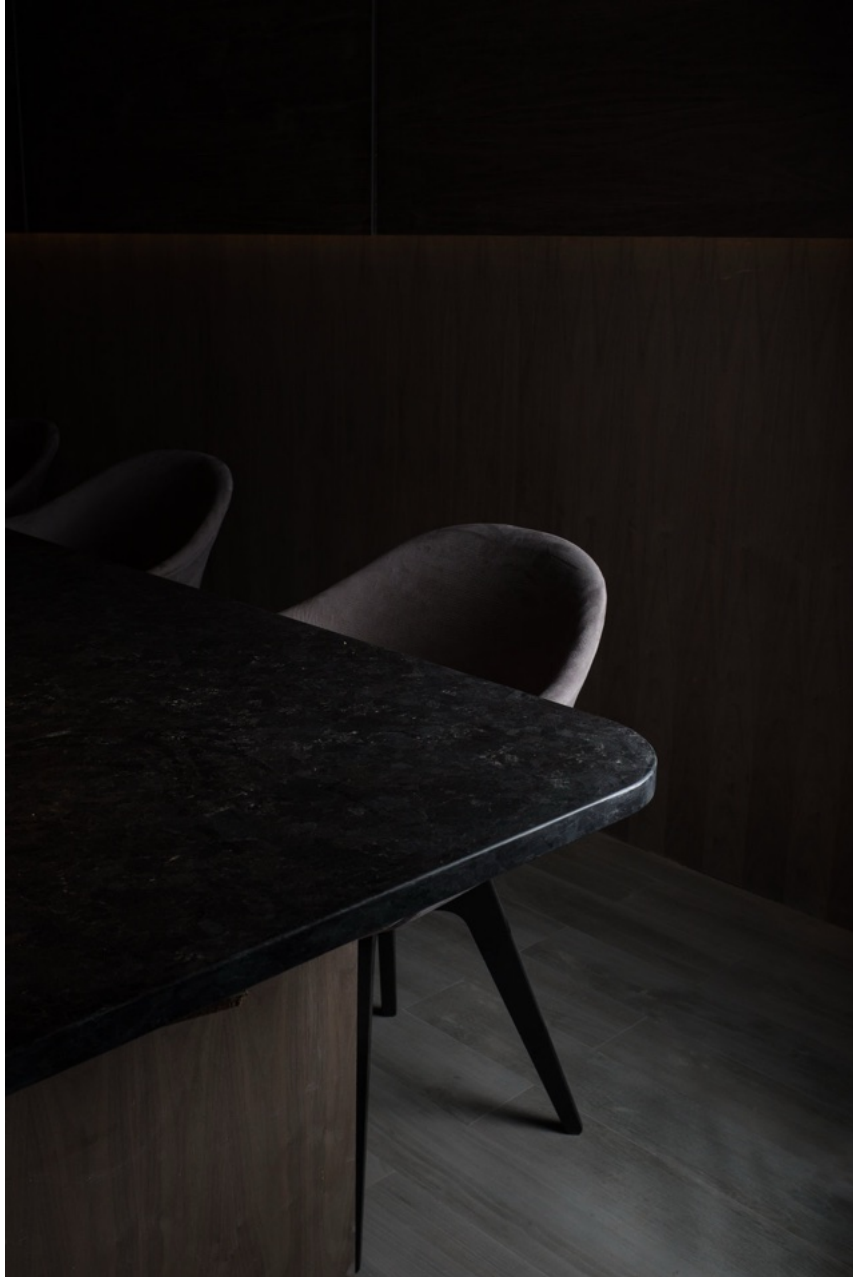




NEW KOREAN CUISINE

Ato, stemming from the ancient Korean word for gift, is the innovative Korean cuisine that husband and wife team - Chef Junghyun and manager Ellia Park, hope to deliver to the world using New York City as their stage. Atomix, a follow-up project to their well-loved firstborn

Atoboy, is a place where guests can really dive deep into Chef Park's cuisine through a 10-course tasting menu featuring modern and traditional techniques that best highlight the new Korean cuisine. Previously, he was the Chef de Cuisine of Jungsik in Tribeca, which was awarded 2-Stars from The Michelin Guide. & Wine's Best New Chef in 2011 and one of Crain's 40 Under 40 honorees in 2015.



CHEF'S COUNTER TASTING MENU

SWEET SHRIMP | Dashima, Bone Marrow

MUSSEL BUN | Myeongran Jeot

SUNDAE | Corn, Black Truffle, Tomato

BUTTERFISH | Eggplant Naengguk, Miyeok, Chervil

KING CRAB | Golden Kaluga Caviar, Celtuce, Gim

RED PEPPER | Jellyfish, Quail Egg, Pine Nut Milk

BAMBOO AND SCALLOP | Black Truffle, Duck Dashi
Potato and Radish Namul, Egg Yolk

SEA CUCUMBER | Jidan, Gochugaru, Shrimp
Squash Stem Rice, Dubujang

SEA BASS | Fava Bean, Monkfish Liver, Black Daepa
Lotus Root Jorim, Soy Milk Gel

LOBSTER | Avocado, Lobster Sauce, Raspberry
Buckwheat Noodle, Gochugaru, Gim

MAESIL | Sugar Snap Pea, Ginger, Chopi

BURDOCK ICE CREAM | Black Truffle, Jocheong, Ricotta



Passing through the small apartment door and the narrow corridor and moving downstairs to the dark and mysterious chamber, I finally arrived at the counter of the famous Atomix, a restaurant that I had always been eager to visit since four years ago. Having just been awarded No.33 on the World's 50 Best Restaurants list, Atomix is about to unveil its summer tasting menu for me.

No sooner had I settled at the counter than the first bite appeared in front of me — a tartellet highlighting amaebi, bone marrow, and dashima. The wasabi-coated amaebi paired with a beef bone marrow sauce nestles in a thin crust made of dashima, a Korean version of kombu, with an additional layer of slivered fresh asparagus. The tartellet crust of dashima reveals a fabulous earthy depth reminiscent of fungus yet provides refreshingly rich umami. In addition, a beef bone marrow sauce blended with fermented soy bean doenjang is introduced to add another layer of depth and richness that enlivens the whole while not intervening with amaebi, the protagonist of the show. Enwrapped in layers and layers of rich deep flavors, the amaebi is hard to be detected, yet enough to reveal its extensively sweet umami and marvelously elastic yet creamy texture.



The second amuse bouche soon lands on the marble table with a different perspective of the ocean creatures. A bun with mussel and Myeongran Jeot showcases Korean's long-term passion for fermented and salted goods. The fermentation and salt-curing process endues the duo with a complex and profound flavor profile, while the bun makes the whole intimate and approachable. An additional hint of spiciness perfectly rejuvenates the medley. My only regret is the bun was overly thick and mushy that ruined the texture of the filling.



Following the two seafood amuse bouches is the final small bite featuring sundae, a Korean version of spicy blood sausage with chili. The sundae is enveloped by sugar bomb tomatoes, Australian winter black truffle, and marigold flower and further topped with a corn meringue and corn powder. The pungent and dark aspects of the sundae are neutralized by the immersive succulence and sweetness of the sugar bomb tomatoes to create a mellow yet still rich and complex flavor profile. Unfortunately, the mild earthiness of the truffle is almost undetectable, and so is the corn flavor of the meringue.



With the limited glance of the three amuse bouches, it is already enough to see the conservative nature of Atomix. Even though the restaurant acclaims itself to be a cutting-edge place serving innovative cuisine, it inevitably keeps reminding us about its Korean root by using many of the ingredients from a relatively mediocre perspective.

Before moving on to the main section of this degustation journey, a set of unique chopsticks showcasing culture and artisanship are presented for each diner to pick their favorite.



Chef Junghyun reimagines naengguk, a Korean cold soup dish typically served in the summertime that plays an essential role in the chef's childhood memory, into this butterfish and eggplant cold soup dish for the very first course of Atomix's new summer menu. In a shining silver ceramic bowl by artist Ki-ra Kim rests a white isle of butterfish, with a chervil salad on top mimicking trees and a crystal clear eggplant naengguk resembling a lake. Even before tasting the dish, such a zen and refreshing presentation already calm the mind down. The raw butterfish from Japan carries a heavenly soft texture and a delicate buttery flavor just as the name suggested. Seasoned with rice vinegar and ginger, then combined with dashima and miyeok, the buttery flavor is transformed into something sensational that gives the tongue a soft kiss yet without covering it with too much unctuousness. The chervil salad comprising fresh chervil, carrot flower, and cilantro flower further lifted the whole with an additional layer of freshness. The star of the dish, however, is the eggplant naengguk. Using some of the most traditional soup seasonings, namely seaweed, onion, ginger, garlic, cheongjang, sugar, mirin, and rice vinegar, the refreshing soup showcases a fine melange of sweetness and sourness and umami from a microscopic level. The dried anchovy and fish sauce, though almost undetectable, are perfect pairings for the eggplant that not only add a hint of sophisticated oceanic umami to the whole but also show Korean's longing for dried goods. Several drops of the perilla oil then ooze another layer of freshness. The eggplant, as the center of the soup, is executed in a way similar to an eggplant otsumami dish in Japanese cuisine, simple yet refreshing. As a matter of fact, the whole dish seems to be strongly influenced by Japanese cuisine — the cold steamed eggplant, the butterfish sashimi, and the use of rice vinegar. Yet chef Junghyun is able to combine these components in a harmonious way that let you feel so simple and so sophisticated at the same time.



In the next course, Chef Junghyun aimed for expressing two of his favorite banchan, gim and gyeranjjim, in a novel way. How to keep the beloved familiarity of these flavors while creating something special, something anew? This was the question chef Junghyun asked himself when creating this dish, and he thought he found the answer in this king crab egg jjim dish. Notwithstanding, I would like to question if this could even be counted as a novel creation. A Korean style gyeranjjim distinguishes itself from a Japanese style chawanmushi with its fluffy and airy texture. A gyeranjjim is a much more rustic steamed egg dish with a lot of air inside, while chawanmushi is ultra delicate and velvety thanks to its higher water-to-egg ratio. It is undeniable that this so-called novel creation by chef Junghyun is just a new version of Japanese chawanmushi. Proofs are found in the silky texture and the use of mirin and dashima in the dashi, the definitive base for chawanmushi. Nothing in this dish reminds me of gyeranjjim except the dried anchovy traditionally used to create the broth base and the shrimp jeot which is also a traditional part of gyeranjjim. Chef Junghyun was trying to find a new way to combine the two banchan, yet he presented us with a Japanese chawanmushi dish, a long-time classic combination of egg and seaweed. Back to the flavor itself, this king crab egg jjim dish is composed of king crab from Norway, Golden Kaluga caviar, julienned celtuce compressed with sesame oil and scallop sauce, gim dashi comprising dashima, dried anchovy, littleneck clam, mirin, Korean radish, shrimp jeot, and gim. It is further finished with some white alyssum flowers and drops of nasturtium oil. The egg is finely prepared, but the king crab is way overcooked, resulting in an unpleasant plastic-like texture. The caviar does provide a luxurious touch of oceanic freshness and rich umami, and celtuce brings something pristine and homey to the whole.



Following the relatively traditional steamed egg dish is probably the most progressive dish on the menu, a dish highlighting red pepper, jellyfish, and pine nut milk. At the heart of the creation exhibits a refreshing jellyfish salad consisting of Jellyfish, red pepper, lemon cucumber, mustard, honey, and winter melon vinegar. The heart is cocooned in a lattice of red pepper noodles. The whole nestles on a bed of quail egg, pine nut crumbles, and pine nut oil. Upon serving, a pine nut milk made with pine nut, brown sugar, and pine nut oil is poured into the dish, further drenching the whole in a warm and voluptuous accord.

Pine nuts have a long tradition in Korean gastronomy and hospitality history. Its prized delicacy has been used for over 2040 years not only to treat guests of honor or to serve the respected elderly as a restorative specialty but also to be enjoyed as something extremely beneficial for health. Today, the pine nut is transformed into the liquid gold that enraptures my palate with extraordinary depth and rich toasted aroma far exceeding almond or cashew milk.



The red pepper, as the other protagonist in this dish, is transformed into agar noodles. The noodles made of red pepper juice, agar, and fish gelatin ooze a naturally sweet and peppery fragrance, yet the texture seems rather disappointing. The agar noodles are too soft and fragile that immediately collapse when chewing. They are far from the ideal elastic and al dente texture. The jellyfish, on the other hand, gives compensation to the textural flaw of the agar noodle. The chewy and crunchy jellyfish provides a solid texture profile to support the rich flavors of the medley.



To convey us with the rustic warmth of Korean cuisine, chef Junghyun designed a dish featuring bamboo and scallop. The concoction is centered on a bamboo jeon comprising bamboo and littleneck clam, topped with thin slices of scallop from Japan brushed with scallop sauce. It is further enriched with some duck powder and duck stock made with duck breast, dashima, Korean radish, jalapeño, ganjang, yondu, and honey. Some Australian summer truffle then gives the dish a crowning touch.

The dish should probably be digested as a whole, as the two main ingredients are engulfed in a tsunami of flavors. The scallop is easier to be examined on its own, but it is hardly possible to detect the bamboo when it is enwrapped in a pancake-like jeon made of littleneck clam, scallion, jalapeño, and egg yolk. The flavor profile in general reads mellow and cozy on the palate. Centered on the rich sweetness and umami and the tofu-like texture of the scallop, the nebulous melange of flavors oozes layers upon layers of earthy aromas and subtle sweetness that gyrates around the cordial spine. The Australian summer truffle, though fades in comparison to the winter truffles that radiate enormous earthy aromas, divulges hints of alluring fragrances that echo the interior bamboo from the outside.

This course is further paired with a banchan — potato radish namul. The dainty bite comprising potato and both watermelon radish and ninja radish is seasoned with grounded sesame seeds that provide a mild aroma as well as egg yolk and hints of wheelk sauce that is house-fermented for years.





In the next main course, chef Junghyun showcases Korea's long-term endearment for dried seafood. As a peninsula nation, dried seafood was key for the inland population of Korea to be able to consume seafood. Dried sea cucumber displays a texture and fragrance that is entirely different from its fresh counterpart. Dried sea cucumbers, after rehydrated, have a chewy and soft texture that's a novelty on its own. While Chinese has a much longer history of consuming dried sea cucumber, chef Junghyun's interpretation of this dried seafood good is also strongly inspired by Chinese cuisine, especially Cantonese according to the maître d'.

In this dish, the precious ocean treasure is stuffed with a shrimp cake made of shrimp, Chinese chive, scallion, sesame oil, and yondu in a similar manner seen in traditional Cantonese dim sum courses. It is then finished with an oil base comprising various spicy ingredients including jalapeño oil, gochugaru, and paprika. The Sea cucumber is further showered in a light yet flavorful Jidan sauce of julienned pan-seared egg, chicken, oyster, garlic, scallion, and jungjang, a special type of premier soy sauce developed by Korean artisanal Ki Soon Do which is aged up to four years.



The sea cucumber is cooked to a softness of perfection that won't lose its essential elastic texture while still being able to deliver its charming tenderness. The shrimp cake sublimated the sea cucumber with its mellow and rich umami, while the jidan sauce and the gochugaru and jalapeño oil further enriched the concoction with a sophisticated brininess and a most gentle punch of spiciness.

The sea cucumber course is paired with a small rice dish. It is a common way to serve a bowl of rice aside from a sea cucumber course in Chinese cuisine, and in this course, chef Junghyun combines such tradition with a Korean rice dish consisting of squash stem rice, aehobak, and dubujang. The mildly spicy zucchini rice is augmented by a heavenly flavorful fermented tofu paste known as dubujang that has been fermented for over a year in-house.



After a mollusk dish and an echinoderm dish, I am presented with a sea bass dish that highlights the seafood session of the menu. The course features sea bass from Japan, rinsed in a rich ankimo sauce of milk, monkfish liver, and doenjang, paired with some fava bean, semi-dried black currants, and chopi, then finished with a piece of black daepa twigim.

Albeit the fact that the dish centers on the sea bass, it is the ankimo sauce that plays an essential role to radiate charms that immediately enrapture the diner's palate. The sauce showcases a unique depth and rich aroma reminiscent of aged vin jaune. It is creamy, nutty, and mellow, similar to foie gras but with more depth rather than simply being unctuous. The sea bass is delicately cooked to a moderate tenderness yet with essential firmness so as to counterweight the rich flavor and the heavy texture of the sauce. The ankimo sauce is further underscored with fava bean which tends to be nuttier, creamier, and earthier than other bean varieties. The fava bean delivers a unique flavor profile that tastes less raw than other beans, almost as if it is aged. On top of the flesh lies a piece of black daepa twigim, finished with some marigold leaves and anise hyssop blossoms. The black daepa twigim directly translates as fried Korean black leek chip, and it consists of grilled daepa, gochugaru, garlic, onion, and black daepa powder. The chip does not contribute much to the concoction with its flavor yet it provides a crispy texture that adds another variety of textures to the medley.



While the fish is delicious on its own, chef Junghyun hopes that the pairing of the lotus root banchan alongside will highlight the ways in which banchan can harmonize and elevate a bite. Banchan makes Korean cuisine more extraordinary as it is the ultimate method of creating harmonious combinations. The banchan comprising soy sauce braised lotus root, soy milk gel, Korean chopi pepper, pickled shiso flower, and toasted sesame seeds is indeed able to orchestrate the concoction in a more comprehensive way by adding a refreshing sweet and sour blend to counter the pure richness of the fish core.



The final savory is original a porcelet dish, but I made a request for a substitution as almost every diner gives this dish a thumbs down. What I receive in lieu of the pork is a dish featuring lobster from Maine, prepared with a lobster head emulsion and an avocado salad of avocado, squash, ramp and sherry vinegar, yondu sauce, and perilla oil, further finished with some chive, salted egg yolk, raspberry powder, and nasturtium blossom. Alongside the lobster dish is a small bowl of buckwheat noodle, seasoned with gochugaru and fuji apple sauce.



Many previous diners complained that the porcelet dish is unbelievably salty. According to the menu, the two primary saline sources should be the doenjang caramel sauce and beltfish innards foam that are originally designated to be served with the porcelet. The lobster version uses lobster head emulsion in substitution for the two sauces, which avoids the thick and heavy doenjang, resulting in a better-balanced salinity. While the head sauce seems quite common, the other ingredients countering the richness of the lobster part are rather fascinating. The avocado functions as a vegan version of butter that eclectically introduces both a creamy buttery texture and a refreshing fruity aroma to the melange. An inner and obscure stream of herbal floral freshness extracted from the raspberry and nasturtium blended with the mellow acidity of the sherry vinegar further refines the medley, lifting the whole to another dimension.

The buckwheat noodle and lobster pairing resembles the classic lobster tagliatelle but in a more refreshing way. The cold buckwheat is similar to cold soba, and the hidden fuji apple sauce further delivers a ripe fruity fragrance. When mixing the lobster and its sauce with the noodle part, a new harmonious opus in which rich crustacean umami coexists with the refreshing mellow fruity floral perfume is created.



After a series of savory courses and banchan, I am presented with a palate cleanser that celebrates Korea's unique yet ephemeral summer treasure — Maesil. At the onset of the summer season is the harvest of the young green plums. As soon as the bounty is harvested, fresh maesil must be made into maesil cheong which is a syrup or jangajji which equals pickles. To make maesil-cheong, maesil is combined with sugar and fermented for about a hundred days. The resulting syrup is used in place of sugar. Atomix makes its own maesil-cheong annually, and today's sorbet highlights the batch made three years ago. Regardless of the fact that this dish functions as a pre-dessert or a palate cleanser, it is rather delicately designed with finesse and artfully prepared. At the center of the dessert is a medallion of maesil sorbet comprising maesil cheong, maesil juice, and lemon juice. It showcases a unique harmony of the deep sweetness resulting from the long-aged maesil-cheong and its natural mellow acidity. The maesil sorbet is further drenched in a pond of sugar snap pea juice accented by strawberry vinegar, ginger juice, and lemon juice. One should also find some ginger compote, Korean pear, and semi-dried plum at the bottom of the dish. A leaf-shaped milk crisp gives the sorbet a crowning touch while drops of oil made with chopi and green peppercorn are introduced to finish the dessert with a mild hint of herbal spiciness. While the pre-dessert exhibits elaboration and exquisiteness, the main dessert surprises me with its poor design completely overshadowed by the maesil sorbet dessert. Neither should the main dessert repeat the ice cream idea shown in the pre-dessert nor should the main dessert be so tiny and anticlimactic. Nonetheless, the taste of the dessert on its own is still fabulous. Similar to the sorbet course, this dish again centers on a scoop of burdock ice cream. The burdock ice cream is astonishingly scrumptious in a unique way reminiscent of cereal milk soft serve at the Milk Bar. The sweetness of the ice cream is further refined and enriched by a drizzle of caramel jocheong, while its barnyard style earthy aroma is enhanced by the Australian summer truffle. In addition to these toppings, small chunks of dried pain au lait made with maple syrup, brown sugar, and truffle oil are added to counter the whole with granola-like crispiness and sophisticated choux pastry aroma.



GLOSSARY

Jang | 장 — Sauce in Korean cuisine.

Doenjang | 된장 — “Thick Sauce” fermented soy bean paste, similar to miso.

Ganjang | 간장 — Korean soy sauce.

Gochujang | 고추장 — Korean red chili paste.

Cheongjang | 청장 — similar to the Japanese white soy sauce.

Dubujang | 두부장 — literally means tofu sauce or bean paste sauce, similar to Chinese 腐乳.

Gochu | 고추 — Korean chili pepper

Gochujang | 고추장 — Korean red chili paste

Gochugaru | 고춧가루 — Korean chili powder

Cheong | 청 — A name for various sweetened foods in the form of syrups, marmalades, and fruit preserves.

Cheongjang | 청장 — similar to the Japanese white soy sauce.

Jocheong | 조청 — a Korean product that is traditionally used as a sweetener or as a substitute for sugar.

Maesil Cheong | 매실청 — Korean green plum extract or syrup.

Jeotgal | 젓갈 — Aka Jeot 젓 translated as salted seafood, is a category of salted preserved dishes made with seafood.

Myeongran Jeot | 명란젓 — Salted pollock roe.

Dashima | 다시마 — Dried seaweed kelp, equivalent to Kombu.

Miyeok | 미역 — Seaweed, aka Wakame.

Kim | Gim | 김 — Dried seaweed, aka Nori.

Guk | 국 — Soup in Korean cuisine.

Naengguk | 냉국 — Chilled soup, mainly served in summer.

Bap | 밥 — a Korean name of cooked rice.

Banchan | 반찬 — a collective name for small side dishes served along with cooked rice in Korean cuisine.

Jangajji | 장아찌 — a pickled vegetable dish, a type of banchan. Unlike kimchi, jangajji is non-fermented vegetables.

Jorim | 조림 — a simmered dish made by boiling vegetables or meat or tofu in seasoned broth until the liquid reduced down.

Jjim | 찜 — a Korean cuisine term referring to dishes made by steaming or boiling meat marinated in a sauce or soup.

Gyeran Jjim | 계란찜 — Korean steamed egg dish.

Jjigae | 찌개 — A Korean stew dish, most commonly as kimchi stew.

Jeon | 전 — is a fritter in Korean cuisine.

Twigim | 튀김 — Korean fried food, like Tempura.

Oi | 오이 — Cucumber

Maesil | 매실 — Fresh plum.

Mu | Moo | 무 — Korean radish.

Aehobak | 애호박 — Korean zucchini.

Daepa | 대파 — large Korean Green Onions aka leek.

Namul | 나물 — Either a variety of edible grass or leaves or seasoned herbal dishes made of them.

Sundae | 순대 — a type of blood sausage in Korean cuisine.

Jidan | 지단 — Egg garnish, pan fried egg sheet that can be cut into strips.

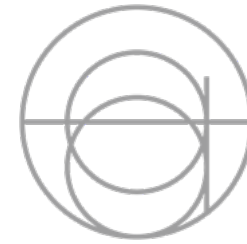
Soju | 소주 — a clear and colorless Korean distilled alcoholic beverage.

Chopi | 초피 — Japanese and Korean pepper, equivalent to sanshō (山椒).

Muchim | 무침 — A Korean cuisine technique that means to mix with seasonings.

Oi Muchim | 오이무침 — A spicy cucumber salad

Yondu | 연두 — an umami sauce made from fermented soybeans and a broth of vegetables and aromatics. Similar to soy sauce.



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